

Email security refers to the practices, tools, and behaviours used to protect email communications from unauthorised access, fraud, and malicious content. Email remains one of the most widely used communication methods for both individuals and organisations, which also makes it a primary target for cyber attacks such as phishing, malware distribution, and credential theft.

Email-based attacks are often effective because they rely on impersonation and deception. Attackers can send messages that appear to come from legitimate organisations, colleagues, or trusted contacts. These messages may contain malicious links, attachments, or requests for sensitive information. In many cases, the goal is to trick the recipient into taking an action that compromises their security.

There are several common risks associated with email communication:

- Phishing emails designed to steal login credentials or personal information
- Malicious attachments that contain malware or ransomware
- Fraudulent requests for payments or sensitive business information
- Spoofed email addresses that impersonate trusted senders
- Links to fake websites that capture entered data
- Business Email Compromise (BEC) attacks targeting organisations and employees

These threats highlight how email is frequently used as an entry point for wider cyber attacks.

Recognising suspicious emails is an important part of maintaining email security. Common warning signs include:

- Unexpected messages requesting sensitive information or urgent action
- Email addresses that do not match the claimed sender or contain subtle misspellings
- Generic greetings rather than personalised communication
- Poor grammar, formatting inconsistencies, or unusual language
- Links that do not match the displayed destination when hovered over
- Attachments that are unexpected or from unknown sources

While some phishing emails can appear highly convincing, these indicators can help users assess whether a message should be trusted.

Protecting email accounts and communications involves several key practices:

- Verifying the sender before responding to requests involving sensitive information
- Avoiding clicking links or downloading attachments from unknown or unexpected emails
- Using multi-factor authentication to secure email accounts
- Accessing websites directly rather than through email links when possible
- Keeping email software and systems updated
- Using strong, unique passwords for email accounts
- Reporting suspicious emails to appropriate providers or internal security teams

For organisations, additional controls are often implemented to reduce email-based risks. These may include spam and phishing filters, email authentication protocols such as SPF, DKIM, and DMARC, and security awareness training for employees. Monitoring and logging email activity can also help detect unusual behaviour and potential compromises.

Email security is critical because email accounts often serve as gateways to other systems and services. If an attacker gains access to an email account, they may be able to reset passwords, access sensitive data, or impersonate the user to carry out further attacks.

This page provides an overview of email security, including common threats, indicators of suspicious activity, and methods used to reduce risk. Understanding how email-based attacks operate is an essential step in protecting both personal and organisational information.